

Afterword by Tom DeFalco

THE AVENGERS is actually the super-team title that Stan Lee was supposed to create at the beginning of the Marvel Universe, but he and Jack Kirby did the Fantastic Four instead. Martin Goodman, who owned the company that would eventually be known as Marvel Comics, was playing golf one day with some big shot from rival DC Comics. Goodman learned that DC's best-selling title was *The Justice League of America*, a team of super heroes, and immediately told Stan to come up with the same thing for Marvel. Well, the Justice League united all of DC's top heroes, but Marvel didn't have any suitable heroes at that precise moment. Stan probably could have resurrected Captain America, Sub-Mariner, and the original Human Torch—which he did later on—but he preferred to stretch his imagination and the boundaries of comics by creating the FF, a super-team for people who didn't like super-teams. When that title proved a success, he introduced more and more heroes until it seemed only natural to team them. Of course, Stan soon grew bored with the Avengers lineup and started changing the team.

If the Avengers can be summed up in a single word, it's "change." The team's membership changed with its second issue. A former member became an enemy with its third issue. A new member was added to the ranks in its fourth issue, and so on. In 2004, the entire structure of the Avengers was disassembled and replaced and that, too, is destined to change. If the Avengers teach us anything, it's that change is inevitable. We have to expect it and deal with it. A worthy lesson for children and adults alike!

Whenever I think of the Avengers, certain issues immediately spring to mind: *Avengers* #4, when Captain America burst on the scene... *Avengers* #9, the introduction and death of Wonder Man... *Avengers* #17, the old order changeth... and *Avengers* #59 where I first learned that even an android can cry. I also think of Stan Lee and Jack Kirby who started the whole ball

rolling and Roy Thomas and John Buscema, who took the team on the wildest rollercoaster rides. The Avengers were produced by a legion of truly talented creative people and I salute them all.

THE TIME HAS COME time has come for me to thank my editor, Alastair Dougall, for his exceptional patience and total support. The book may not have had all the angst and trauma of the last one, but life still did get a tad too interesting along the way.

I am also grateful to the talented Lisa Lanzarini who designed this book and keeps getting better with each new set of layouts.

While the original comics were my actual source material, I also relied rather heavily on the work of people like Mark Gruenwald, Peter Sanderson, Elliot Brown, Howard Mackie, Mark Bernardo, Bob Budiansky, Tom Brevoort, Eric Fein and all the others who contributed to *The Official Handbook of the Marvel Universe* (all three editions).

Anyone interested in the Avengers should also look in on the current monthly comic books—*New Avengers*, *Young Avengers*, *Ultimates* and, of course, *Iron Man*, and *Captain America*. The Avengers earlier adventures have been reprinted in a variety of formats, from the *Marvel Masterworks* to the *Essential Editions* and dozens of trade paperbacks.

This book is dedicated to Jimmy, Samantha, Bernie, Eddy, Tommy, Danielle, Christopher, Allison, Stephen, Meredith, Alexa, Andrew, Gerald, Carolyn, Ryan and the new addition we're expecting in November—they are my mightiest heroes and I thank them for helping me carry on and for giving me a reason to remain a storyteller. I would also like to express my gratitude to you, my reader, for just being there!

HOO-HA!

Tom D.

